

CINECAST

A PODCAST ON BANGLADESHI CINEMA

Why Doesn't Bangladesh Make Science Fiction Movies?

Episode 01

HOST Faria Akhtar **GUEST** Mahbubul Ontor, *Former CEO, Cinemascope*

COLD OPEN

FARIA Science fiction is one of the most beloved genres of our generation. I mean—who doesn't love a good sci-fi movie? But how long can we keep watching science fiction made in other countries? Don't we deserve Bangladeshi science fiction too? Sci-fi in the Bangladeshi film industry... well, that's a conversation. Hello, and welcome to our podcast, Cinecast. Today's topic: "Why doesn't the Bangladeshi film industry make science fiction movies?" I'm your host, Faria Akhtar, and our guest today is Mahbubul Ontor, former CEO of Cinemascope. Hello!

MAHBUBUL Hello.

FARIA Would you introduce yourself to our audience?

MAHBUBUL Sure. As you said, I'm the former CEO of Cinemascope. Beyond that, I've worked in the TV industry for several years, and these days I'm exploring the world of Bangladeshi cinema across different genres. It's been about fourteen or fifteen years now that I've been studying filmmaking. So—yeah, that's me.

SEGMENT 1 — Budget or Imagination?

FARIA Let's get into it. Why aren't there any science fiction movies in the Bangladeshi film industry?

MAHBUBUL Honestly? To make a science fiction film, you need a huge budget. Think about films like *Interstellar* or *Gravity*—those sat right at the top of their budget lines. And then there's the other side: imagination. I think Bangladeshi filmmakers—not Bangladesh, but our filmmakers specifically—are lacking on both fronts. We don't have the budget to make these films, and we don't have the imagination to bring out something new, to explore something new.

FARIA Budget is a fair point. But plenty of Hollywood science fiction movies have succeeded at the box office on tiny budgets. *Coherence*, *Donnie Darko*, *The Butterfly Effect*—all good examples. You might be surprised to learn *Coherence* was made for just fifty thousand dollars. So do you really think budget is the obstacle for us?

MAHBUBUL That's exactly my point. The bigger thing our filmmakers—our whole industry—lacks right now is imagination. Thinking of something new, creating something new. Take *Coherence*: they didn't need spectacle to tell that story. It was a simple story built on a science fiction idea. They had the imagination to pull it off—and that's what we need right now.

SEGMENT 2 — Can Ananta Jalil Save the Industry?

FARIA Ananta Jalil made *Din: The Day* with a budget of a hundred crore taka. Could he be the savior of our industry when it comes to big-budget science fiction?

MAHBUBUL First of all, Ananta Jalil's film wasn't actually a hundred-crore film—there were some controversies there, and I don't want to go down that road and get myself in trouble. Look, I won't call Ananta Jalil a great actor. But when it comes to his passion for film—his passion for making films on a big budget—I'd say he could be a real asset as a producer. If he put his money behind filmmakers like Nuhash Humayun, or other directors doing genuinely great, creative work, that combination—creative thinking plus a serious producer—could make the industry explode.

SEGMENT 3 — Do We Really Lack the Stories?

FARIA Do you really think we lack science fiction stories? We have so much material in our publishing world—so many well-written science fiction books. So do we actually lack stories, or is turning a story into a movie the real problem?

MAHBUBUL If you look at our literature, we have tons of science fiction books. But the film industry isn't adapting any of it. I'd say today's filmmakers don't really read. They fall back on a familiar formula and build films around that formula. So no—we don't lack stories. We just can't visualize them.

FARIA That makes sense. Alright, viewers—we're taking a quick break. Don't worry, we'll be right back.

SPONSOR BREAK

FARIA Hello, and welcome back to the show. I'm your host, Faria Akhtar, here with our guest, Mahbubul Ontor. Shall we get back to it?

MAHBUBUL Are you asking my permission?

FARIA Maybe.

MAHBUBUL Then it's a green light for me!

SEGMENT 4 — Going International

FARIA *MR-9: Do or Die* released internationally this week, on a budget of around eighty-three crore taka. Do you think making a science fiction movie as an international production could ease the pressure of a big budget?

MAHBUBUL On the collaboration side—*MR-9* worked with US actors, and I think that was a smart move by the directors. So yes, this could be a good way to explore the world alongside other film industries.

SEGMENT 5 — What Can Campus Clubs Do?

FARIA Clubs like the ULAB Film Club and Media Club, or apprenticeship programs like Cinemascope, could screen more science fiction on campus. Do you think that would encourage young ULAB filmmakers—or is there something else these clubs and programs should be doing?

MAHBUBUL Look—watching a film and actually walking away inspired is rare. If I force a student to sit through a two-and-a-half or three-hour film with me, or with a club or apprenticeship program, it's not going to help. They'll just get bored. But if the passion is already there, and the club or program is genuinely trying to reach them, then they need to be smarter about how they do it—use some real tactics.

OUTRO & CREDITS

FARIA And I think that's a wrap for today. It's been an epic conversation with Mahbubul Ontor about making science fiction in our industry. Special thanks to our guest, Mahbubul Ontor, for being here and spending time with us. Thanks to Tariquzzaman Shikdar for all the table work, thanks to Uchhas Ahmed Bappi for the technical support—and thanks to myself, for being the best host in this room right now.

MAHBUBUL Ah, you're the best. Thank you so much for having me.

FARIA And that's it for today's episode. We'll be back with our second episode—if we ever retake this course. Till then, goodbye. See you soon!

— END OF EPISODE —